

KASANDY FOUNDATION

Kasandy Circular Economy Initiative

RESEARCH BRIEF

Circular Economy Employment: International Models

Comparative analysis of inclusive employment in circular textile economy ventures
across France, Australia, and the Netherlands — and implications for KCEI.

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Circular Economy Employment: International Models

The Kasandy Circular Economy Initiative is not the first organization to ask whether textile waste can be turned into employment. Across France, Australia, and the Netherlands, several ventures have demonstrated that circular textile models can generate meaningful work — though the depth of the social employment mandate varies significantly. This brief provides a comparative review of the three most instructive international models, identifying what KCEI can learn and where it diverges with intention.

Summary: Three models reviewed

- FabBrick (France, 2018) — Circular product pioneer. Social employment limited. 12 tonnes/year artisanal scale.
- UPPAREL (Australia, 2020) — Circular scale leader. Commercial focus. Limited inclusive employment mandate.
- Renewal Workshop (USA, 2015) — Brand take-back model. Not post-consumer. No inclusive employment design.

MODEL 1: FABBRICK, FRANCE

FabBrick — Paris, France (Est. 2018)

FabBrick, founded by architect Clarisse Merlet, converts shredded textile waste into decorative acoustic bricks using an ecological binder. The bricks are non-structural but have demonstrated commercial application in retail interiors, office partition systems, and exhibition design. Major clients include Galeries Lafayette, Vinci, IKEA, and Google.

Scale & production

FabBrick has produced approximately 40,000 bricks since 2018, recycling a total of 12 metric tonnes of textile waste (Interni Magazine, 2024). This averages approximately 2 tonnes per year — an artisanal scale made possible by a handmade production process. The company has developed automated equipment to scale but has been cautious about industrialization. The model is funded through product sales and brand collaborations.

Employment model

FabBrick employs a small core team in Paris. There is no documented inclusive employment mandate — workers are primarily design and architecture professionals. This is the key distinction from KCEI, which was designed from the ground up to employ refugees, newcomers, and people with disabilities.

KCEI comparison

- Product similarity: High. KCEI acoustic bricks use the same concept (shredded textile + binder + compression)
- Scale target: KCEI targets 50 tonnes/Year 1 — 4× FabBrick's cumulative 6-year output using industrial equipment
- Employment: KCEI has a deep social employment mandate. FabBrick does not.
- Market: FabBrick sells primarily to design and brand clients. KCEI targets municipal procurement.

MODEL 2: UPPAREL, AUSTRALIA

UPPAREL — Melbourne, Australia (Est. 2020)

UPPAREL is Australia's largest textile recovery company, operating a nationwide collection and processing system for unwanted textiles. The company collects textiles from consumers via a pre-paid postal service, sorts them into reuse, repurpose, or recycle streams, and partners with downstream manufacturers to convert non-wearable textiles into insulation, acoustic panels, sports surfaces, and industrial applications.

Scale & production

UPPAREL does not publish precise diversion tonnage but has processed millions of items since 2020. It operates at commercial scale across Australia, with partnerships including mainstream retailers and corporate take-back programs. The model is B2B-oriented: UPPAREL collects the waste stream and contracts out processing to industrial partners.

Employment model

UPPAREL's employment model is commercial. There is no documented inclusive employment mandate. Jobs are primarily in logistics, sorting, and commercial operations.

KCEI comparison

- Logistics: UPPAREL's postal collection model is a useful reference for KCEI's eventual collection expansion
- Products: UPPAREL's output categories (insulation, acoustic panels, sports surfaces) significantly overlap with KCEI's product roadmap
- B2C vs B2B: KCEI is designed with both community collection and municipal procurement; UPPAREL is primarily B2B
- Employment: KCEI's inclusive employment mandate is a deliberate structural differentiator from UPPAREL's commercial model

MODEL 3: RENEWAL WORKSHOP, USA

Renewal Workshop — Oregon, USA (Est. 2015)

The Renewal Workshop partners with clothing brands to receive returned, damaged, and slow-moving inventory, repairs and refurbishes garments for resale through partner channels, and processes non-recoverable items into fibre for industrial applications. Brand partners have included Prana, Eileen Fisher, and REI.

Model structure

The Renewal Workshop operates as a B2B service for brands, not as a post-consumer waste processor. Its inputs come from brand inventory and take-back programs, not from household waste streams. This makes it a fundamentally different model from KCEI — it is dependent on brands rather than on waste infrastructure.

Employment model

The Renewal Workshop documented the creation of local living-wage jobs in Oregon, with a focus on textile repair trades. This is a partial parallel to KCEI's Rework & Repair service stream. No specific inclusive employment mandate is documented.

KCEI comparison

- Input model: Renewal Workshop requires brand partnerships. KCEI processes post-consumer waste directly — more resilient, not brand-dependent
- Rework/repair: KCEI's service stream mirrors Renewal Workshop's core activity
- Employment: KCEI's inclusive employment design is more intentional and structured

SYNTHESIS: WHERE KCEI STANDS

KCEI in Global Context

Across all three international comparators, KCEI occupies a unique position: it is the only model reviewed that combines (1) industrial-scale post-consumer textile processing, (2) manufactured product output with municipal procurement potential, and (3) a deep, structured inclusive employment mandate. The international evidence supports the core KCEI hypothesis: the circular textile economy can create living-wage employment, process meaningful volumes of waste, and supply products to institutional buyers. What KCEI adds is the deliberate targeting of equity-deserving workers as the manufacturing workforce.

KCEI structural advantages vs. international comparators

- Only Canadian full-stack model: collection + processing + manufacturing + municipal sales
- Inclusive employment mandate is structural, not incidental: designed for 6 equity communities
- Municipal procurement focus: KCEI targets City of Vancouver, CRD, City of Victoria — larger, more stable market
- Research-backed: ECUAD MOU for materials science validation — FabBrick and UPPAREL lack formal research partnerships

- Government-funded pilot: FFBC + SBCCI validation at the systemic level

Sources: FabBrick.com; Interni Magazine (2024); UPPAREL.com.au; Renewal Workshop impact reports; OR Foundation textile trade research; University of Waterloo (2023); Ellen MacArthur Foundation, A New Textiles Economy (2017); WRAP Textiles 2030 reports. kasandyfoundation.org.